BRITISH COUNCIL

LearnEnglish

Name: _____

Roll No: _____

Class No: _____

Describing charts

Before reading

Do the preparation task first. Then read the text and tips and do the exercises.

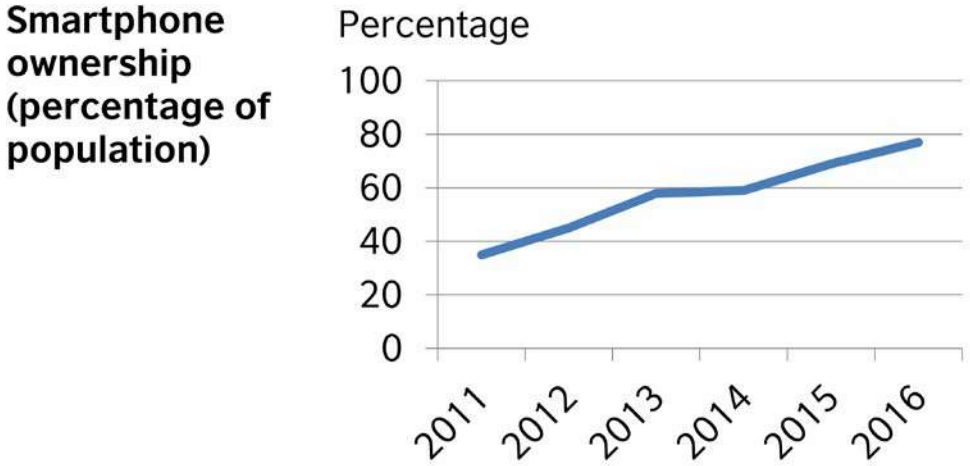
Preparation task
Put these words in the correct group.

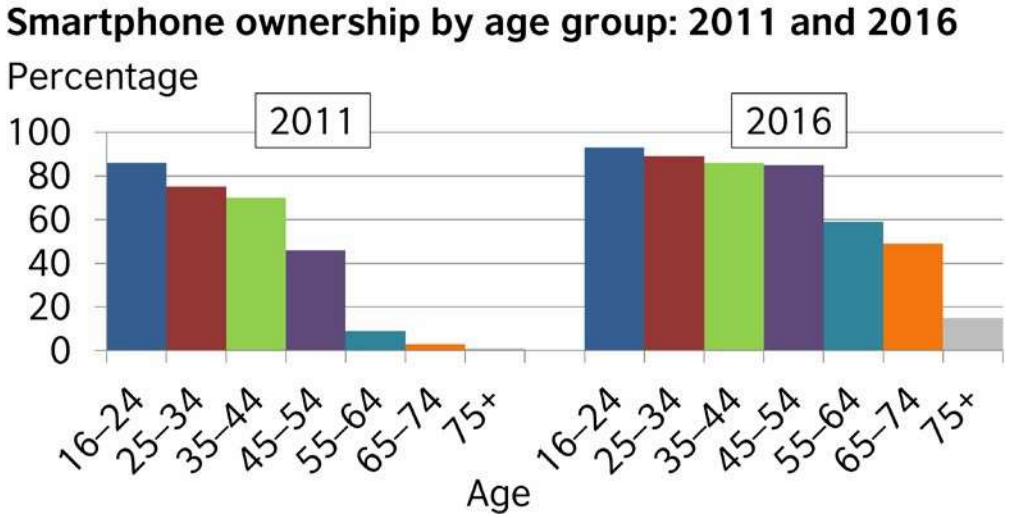
suddenly	steadily	to fall
to go up	to grow	to rise
to go down	to shrink	gradually

verbs that mean ***to decrease***	**verbs that mean** ***to increase***	**adverbs that describe change**

© 2020 British

Reading text: Describing charts





The first chart illustrates the percentage of the population who owned a smartphone from 2011 to 2016, and the second breaks the percentages down by age for 2011 and 2016.

Overall, smartphone ownership increased during the six-year period. In general, the younger people were, the more likely they were to own a smartphone. However, the most significant increases in smartphone ownership between 2011 and 2016 came from people aged 45 to 54, from 46% to 84%; from those in the 55 to 64 category, from 9% to 59%; and from those
aged 65 to 74, from 5% to 50%.

The percentage of people who owned a smartphone rose steadily, starting at around 35% in 2011 and reaching about 77% by 2016. People aged 16 to 24 represented the greatest percentage of smartphone ownership in both 2011 and 2016. 75% of people aged 25 to 34 and 72% of those aged 35 to 44 owned a smartphone in 2011, rising to 88% and 86% respectively by 2016.

Although almost nobody in the 75+ age category owned a smartphone in 2011, 15% of this group owned smartphones in 2016.

© 2020 British

Please note: This page was designed for writing practice only. Information and statistics in the charts may not be accurate.

.....

Tips

1. If you are doing an exam task, read the instructions and make sure you write according to the word and time limits.
2. Start by saying what the charts show. In an exam, change the words in the question to write the first sentence of your answer, e.g. *These charts show* = *These charts illustrate*.
3. The second paragraph should provide an overview of the key features of the information.
4. The other paragraphs should describe the patterns or trends in more detail. However, only select the most important ones to write about, and don't write about your own ideas.
5. Use linking words and a range of vocabulary to describe what you see in the charts. (You can write % or per cent, but be consistent.)
6. Be careful to use the correct tenses to describe the time periods shown.

Tasks

Task 1

Are the sentences true or false?

	Answer	
1. The first sentence should explain what the charts show.	True	False
2. The detailed information should go after the description of the main trends or findings.	True	False
3. It is a good idea to repeat words to show you know how to use them.	True	False
4. If you write over the word limit in an exam you may lose marks.	True	False
5. It's a good idea to bring in your own general knowledge of the world to explain the trends shown in the charts.	True	False
6. You should try to use a range of language to describe the charts accurately.	True	False

© 2020 British

Task 2

Match the sentences or phrases with the same meaning.

Sales grew in 2002.	Sales rose steadily.	Sales increased the most in 2002.
The charts illustrate the changes in …	Overall, …	2002 had the highest sales.

1. The graphs show the trends in … ……
2. In general, … …… …… ……
3. The biggest increase in sales was in 2002. …… ……
4. There was a steady rise in sales. …… ……
5. Sales saw growth in 2002. …… ……
6. The highest sales come from 2002. …… ……

Task 3

Write the word to fill the gap.

1. The charts illustrate the percentage of the population who owned their homes …… 1995 to 2015.
2. Overall, home ownership increased the first eight years of the period.
3. The younger people were, less likely they were to own their homes.
4. The most significant increase home ownership came from people aged 75 and over.
5. From 2005, home ownership fell most for people aged 18 29.
6. The percentage of people owning their homes started around 64% in 1995.
7. The total percentage of people who owned their homes rose 69% in 2004.
8. Home ownership fell again 69% to 64% by 2015.

Discussion

© 2020 British

Do you ever have to write about charts at work or for your studies?

UNIT ONE
1.6 Presenting and Describing Visuals

In many assignments it is essential to support your arguments with statistics. Visual devices such as graphs and tables are a convenient way of displaying large quantities of information in a form that is easy to understand.

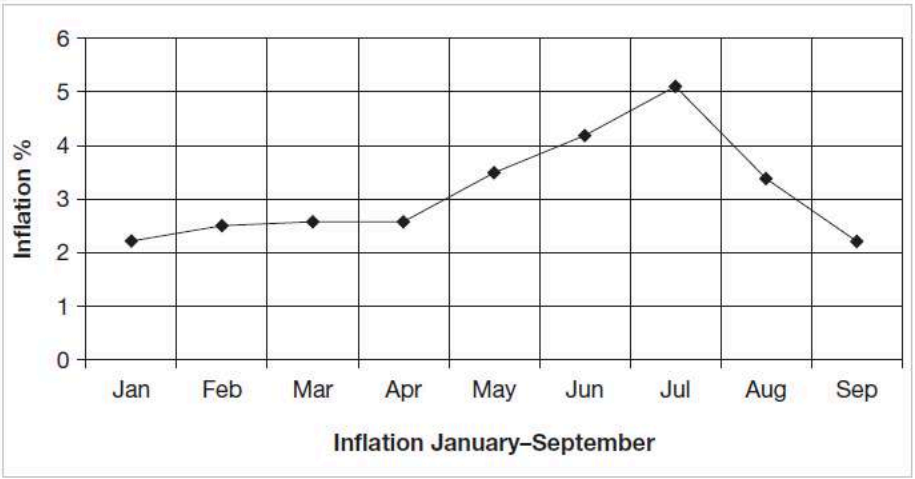
1. The Language of Change

Verb ↗	Adverb	Verb ↘	Adjective + noun
grow (grew)	slightly	drop (dropped)	a slight drop
rise (rose)	gradually	fall (fell)	a gradual fall
increase (increased)	steadily	decrease (decreased)	a sharp decrease
climb (climbed)	sharply	decline (declined)	a steady decline
also: a peak, to peak, a plateau, to level off, a trough			

Average temperatures **rose steadily** until 2006 and then **dropped slightly.**

There was a **sharp decrease** in sales during the summer and then a **gradual rise.**

Study the graph below and complete the description with phrases from the table opposite.



The graph shows that inflation (a) _____ slightly between January and February and then (b) _____ until April. It subsequently climbed (c) _____ to July, when it (d) _____ at just over 5 per cent. From July to September inflation (e) _____ steeply.

2. Types of visuals

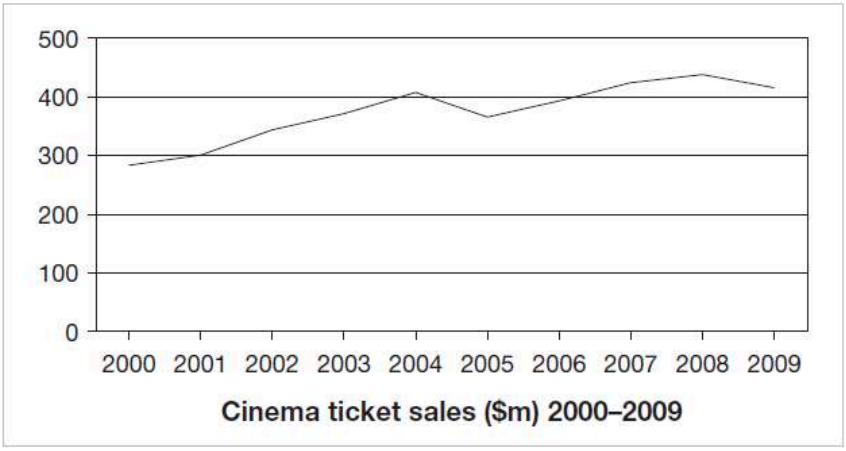
Following are the examples of some of the main types of visuals used in academic texts. Complete the table to show the use (a–f) and the example (A–F) of each type.

Uses:

(a) location
(b) comparison
(c) proportion
(d) function
(e) changes in time
(f) statistical display

TYPES	USES	EXAMPLE
1 diagram		
2 table		
3 map		
4 pie chart		
5 bar chart		
6 line graph		

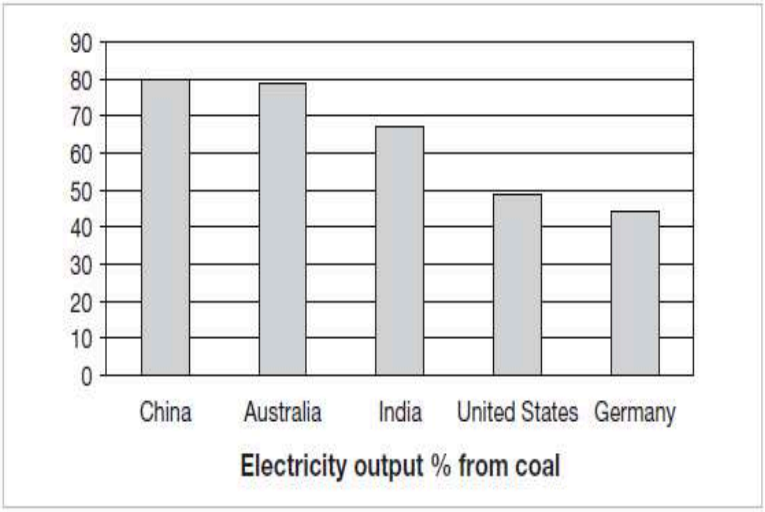
(A) Cinema ticket sales



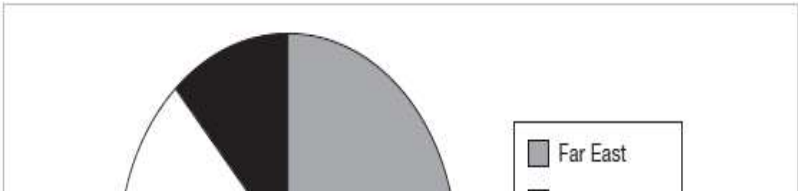
(B) Average life expectancy (in years)

Japan	81.6
France	79.0
United States	77.1
South Korea	75.5
Ghana	57.9
South Africa	47.7
Kenya	44.6
Zimbabwe	33.1

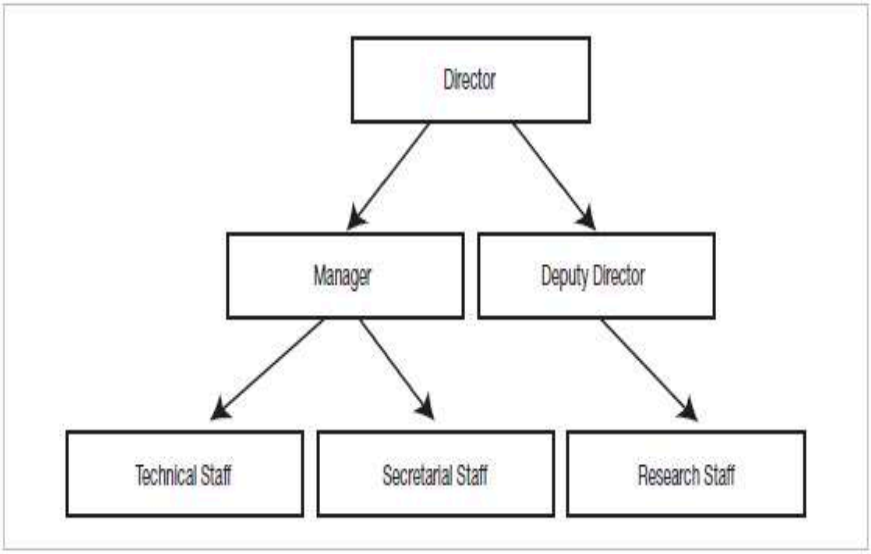
(C) Electricity output from coal



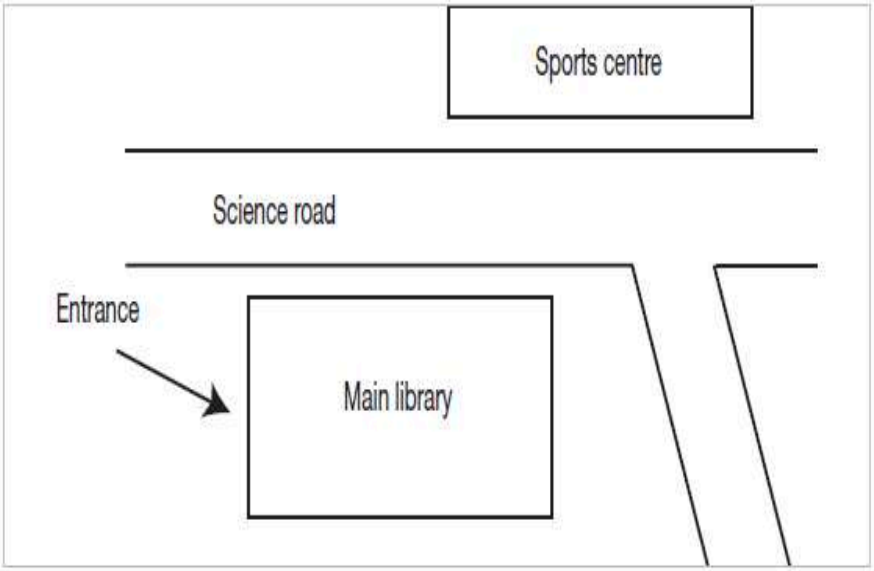
(D) Origins of international students



(E) Structure of the research unit



(F) Position of the main library

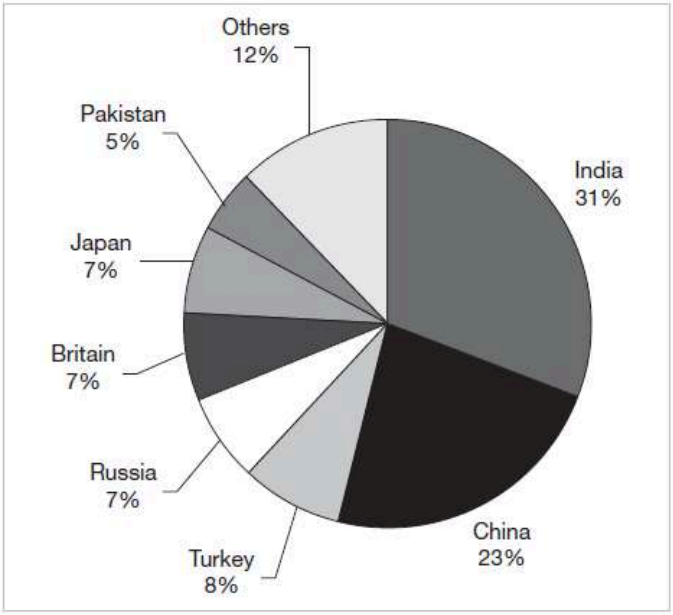


Task: Read the following descriptions of the chart below. Which is better, and why?

(i) The chart shows the quantity of tea consumed by the world's leading tea consuming nations. India and China together consume more than half the world's tea production, with India alone consuming about one third. Other significant tea consumers are Turkey, Russia and Britain. 'Others' includes the United States, Iran and Egypt.

(ii) The chart shows that 31 per cent of the world's tea is consumed by India, 23 per cent by China, and 8 per cent by Turkey. The fourth largest consumers are Russia, Japan and Britain,

with 7 per cent each, while Pakistan consumes 5 percent. Other countries account for the remaining 12 per cent.



(Source:
The Tea Council)

Figure 1 World tea consumption

4 Labelling

- When referring to visual information in the text, the word 'figure' is used for almost everything (such as maps, charts and graphs) except tables (see examples above).
- Figures and tables should be numbered and given a title. Titles of tables are written above, while titles of figures are written below the data.
- As with other data, sources must be given for all visual information.
- If you are writing a lengthy work such as a dissertation you will need to provide lists of tables and figures, showing numbers, titles and page numbers after the contents page.

Task: Complete the following description of the table below (one word per gap).

Projected population changes in various European countries 2010–2050 (millions).

Country	Population 2010	Projected population 2050	Change
France	62	67	+ 5
Germany	82	71	– 11
Italy	60	57	– 3
Poland	38	32	– 6
Portugal	10.7	10	– 0.7
Russia	140	116	– 24
Spain	45	51	+ 6
UK	61	72	+ 10

The table (a) _____ the projected population changes in (b) _____ European countries (c) _____ 2010 and 2050. It can be seen that in a (d) _____ the population is expected to fall, in some cases (i.e. Germany and Russia) quite (e) _____. However, the population of France, (f) _____ and the UK is predicted to increase, in the case of the last two by more (g) _____ 5 per cent.

Task: Write a paragraph commenting on the data in the table below.

Student survey of library facilities: percentage of students rating facilities as good.

Library facilities	Undergraduates	Postgraduates
Opening hours	72	63
Staff helpfulness	94	81
Ease of using electronic catalogue	65	87
Availability of working space	80	76
Café area	91	95
Availability of short loan stock	43	35